

Social Media Safety Guide

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Understanding the Risks

Social media can be a fantastic tool for connecting with friends, family, and sharing interests. However, like any powerful tool, it comes with potential risks, especially for young people. It's important to be aware of these risks so you can use social media safely and confidently.

Here are some key areas to be mindful of:

- **Privacy:** Sharing too much personal information can expose you to unwanted attention or even identity theft. This includes your full name, address, school, phone number, and even your daily routine.
- **Cyberbullying:** Mean or hurtful comments, threats, or the spreading of rumors online can have a significant impact on your well-being. It's crucial to know how to deal with it and who to report it to.
- **Online Predators:** Some adults may pretend to be younger than they are to gain trust and potentially harm young people. It's vital to be cautious about who you talk to online and never agree to meet someone you only know from the internet without a trusted adult's permission and supervision.
- **Misinformation and Scams:** Not everything you see online is true. Be critical of information, especially if it seems too good to be true or is trying to get you to click on suspicious links or share sensitive data.
- **Screen Time and Mental Health:** Spending too much time on social media can sometimes lead to feelings of comparison, FOMO (Fear Of Missing Out), and can affect sleep patterns and overall mood.

Staying Safe Online: Your Digital Toolkit

Protecting Your Privacy

- **Strong Passwords:** Use a mix of uppercase and lowercase letters, numbers, and symbols. Don't use easily guessable information like your birthday.
- **Privacy Settings:** Regularly check and update your privacy settings on all social media platforms. Make sure only your trusted friends can see your posts.
- **Think Before You Post:** Once something is online, it can be very difficult to remove. Consider if you'd be happy for anyone (your parents, teachers, future employers) to see it.
- **Location Services:** Be cautious about sharing your location. Turn off location services for social media apps when not needed.

Dealing with Cyberbullying & Unwanted Contact

- **Don't Respond:** Engaging with a cyberbully often makes the situation worse. Instead, block them immediately.
- **Save Evidence:** Take screenshots of any bullying messages or posts. This can be important if you need to report it.
- **Tell Someone You Trust:** Talk to a parent, guardian, teacher, school counselor, or another trusted adult. You don't have to go through this alone.
- **Report It:** Most social media platforms have ways to report bullying and inappropriate content. Use these tools.
- **Be Wary of Strangers:** If someone you don't know online asks for personal information or to meet up, do not agree. Tell an adult immediately.

Activity: Your Social Media Safety Check-up

Take some time to go through the following checklist. Be honest with yourself! This is about making sure you're as safe as possible.

1. **Review Your Privacy Settings:** Go to your most used social media app right now. Check your privacy settings. Are they set to 'Friends Only' or a similar level of privacy? Are there any apps or websites connected to your social media account that you don't recognize or use anymore? *If you make any changes, note them down.* (Example: 'Changed Instagram to private.')
2. **Check Your 'Friends' List:** Scroll through your followers or friends list. Is there anyone on there you don't know or don't feel comfortable with? Would you be okay if your parents saw everything you post? *If you remove anyone, make a note.* (Example: 'Removed 3 unknown accounts from TikTok.')
3. **What Personal Information is Visible?** Look at your profile. Can people easily see your full name, school, birthday, or current location? If so, consider changing this information to be more general or removing it. *Note any changes.* (Example: 'Changed my birthday to just the day and month on Snapchat.')
4. **Think About Your Last Post:** What did you share recently? Was it something positive and appropriate? If you're unsure, it's a good idea to re-evaluate before posting.
5. **Do You Know Who to Talk To?** Identify at least two adults you can talk to if you ever feel unsafe or uncomfortable online. Write down their names. This could be a parent, aunt, uncle, older sibling, teacher, or counselor.

Reflection: After completing this check-up, what's one thing you learned or one change you plan to make to improve your online safety?

Remember:

Your safety and well-being are the most important things. Social media should be a fun and positive experience. By being aware and taking proactive steps, you can enjoy the benefits of online connections while minimizing the risks. If you ever feel unsure or unsafe, don't hesitate to reach out to a trusted adult.